

A Danish Student's Story

Excerpt: The Licentiate

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The Licentiate

Three years ago, the family at Ravnshøj and a number of their well-to-do neighbors, who have no publicly appointed physician in their vicinity, had joined together to engage a doctor at their own expense. I resolved to seize this opportunity to bring my dear kinsman into some kind of occupation. For he is himself far too lame of will to carry out any decision. I put a letter in his pocket, set him on a goods wagon, and thought the matter perfectly in order. But when a year or so later I made my way out there to see how he was managing in his new position, and for this purpose had myself taken to the local physician, I found to my great astonishment that another doctor was practicing his art in that part of the country. I now resolved to go back to the city to seek out the Licentiate there if possible. On the way I spent the night at the Mill Inn, and there, while I sat in the evening dusk with the jolly landlord watching the fire in the tile stove, I saw a tall, crooked figure steal along the wall and disappear through one of the doors. This figure I shall describe; for in so doing I describe my cousin at the same time. He stands three and a half ells tall, and out of shame at this supernatural height, which is made all the more conspicuous by his slenderness, he bends his back so far that his head falls below the sight-line of an ordinary human being. Nature has eased him in this posture by furnishing his spine with two joints,

so that it forms, especially when he is seated, three lines making two obtuse angles with one another. Otherwise there is nothing remarkable about his exterior, save for a clubfoot, which makes it necessary for him to wear a lace-up boot on his right foot.

— What sort of man was that? I asked the landlord.

— He is one of my guests, he replied; he arrived at my house a year ago and appeared to be in great haste, for he ordered hot water for the following morning at four o'clock, so as to continue his journey in good time. But the next day he cancelled the carriage. He repeated this every day for the first half year; but now it seems he has settled in here at my house. He is a good fellow who never gets in anyone's way; but I believe, to tell the truth, he is not quite right in the head. His learning has driven him out of his senses.

— Choose your words carefully, I said, for he is my own first cousin on my mother's side.

— Ah, he said, then you must know best yourself how he is. He is terribly unsociable. Yesterday he had a ladder set to his room window, so that he could come down into the garden and take his customary exercise without going through the taproom. Sometimes he lies in a stupor the whole day; sometimes he paces up and down the floor and begins to hold forth to himself. But it is quite superfluous for me to tell you such things. You must surely know his peculiarities best yourself. He gives us no trouble, as I said. We have grown so accustomed to seeing him lumber about the house that I even believe we should miss him if he went away. My daughter Marie takes great care to see that he gets his food and drink in good time, for otherwise I believe he would forget himself and simply starve to death. I tell her often enough: let us see for once whether nature itself cannot remind him. He is so tall, after all, that he ought to be able to make some demand upon himself. But she is too soft-hearted to attempt the experiment. —

I sat up until well into the night writing letters, and all the while heard him continually stirring in his room. Now he would play a few minutes on his flute, now he would pace about his floor in silence with heavy steps. I went out into the garden to peep through his windows. The candle on his table had burned far down into the socket, for in his unearthly thoughts he had forgotten to push it up. The flame rose and fell in the tin tube, which was quite blue from the heat, and the melted tallow spread its stench through the whole room. Half lying, half sitting, he was ensconced

in a very low armchair, with his long legs stretched out on the floor. He was sunk in contemplation and stared fixedly before him through his spectacles. Both his hands, which still held the flute, lay entirely motionless in his lap. I watched him for several minutes without his making any sign of moving a limb. Had I not seen the burning gaze through the spectacles, I would have taken it for a successful wax cast of my cousin the Licentiate. At last I called to him through the open window: Good evening, cousin! — He started, without being brought out of his petrified posture. I then crawled through the window with the help of the recently installed ladder, and by the force of my fists brought him out of his stupor. He rose with a good many embarrassed bows and stammered some incomplete compliments, by which he expressed his thanks that I had so willingly taken the trouble of helping a little with his plan of life, and made a number of apologies for not having followed the course I had prescribed for him. His thoughts move so slowly that he sometimes lacks the presence of mind to answer the simplest question. He is especially incomprehensible when he has lately been rapt in his metaphysical reveries. At such times there is such a divorce between his words and his meaning that he is unable to produce any complete sentence; all his thoughts are stillborn. When some equilibrium had been restored to his scattered mind, he made his confession, which — with the omission of his frequent pauses and failed periods — ran as follows:

— The day after I arrived here, it was my firm intention to go to Ravnshøj; but I found it impossible to locate my pocket-scissors, and you would hardly require me to present myself to a household with unclipped fingernails. When the following day I grasped a firebrand from the chimney to light my pipe, I burnt a large blister on my right forefinger. With such a physical pain, you will readily understand that I lacked the free circulation of mind required when one is to introduce oneself with a suitable greeting to a real Councillor's wife. When on the third day the miller's wife, following my instructions, was dressing my injured hand, and wished to burn the thread over with a lit taper, seven large drops of tallow fell on my black coat. When the first drop fell I foresaw that more would follow; but I was so overcome with gratitude for her solicitude that I had not the courage to draw her attention to it. A long time then passed before I managed to procure some turpentine to remove these spots. Meanwhile my finest collars had become soiled, and several weeks elapsed before I had them sent to a washerwoman. With such small misfortunes, sent down

upon me by a malicious demon, a year passed without it being possible for me to get to Ravnshøi, which lies only half a mile from this inn.

— But good Lord, I exclaimed, how is it conceivable that on not a single one of those 365 days you could muster the heroism to make that herculean effort in spite of all obstacles?

— That, he replied, is what you and everyone who has the good fortune to be able to act without reflecting on their life are always saying. Had I been able to discern any sufficient reason why the journey should take place on one day rather than another, it would have come about. But the misfortune consists precisely in this, that I see far too clearly the truth that any action can without serious harm be postponed a day.

— But there you are simply wrong, cousin, I replied; nothing in the world that can be done today ought to be put off till tomorrow.

— If you deny me that, he took up again, then you must necessarily grant me that it can possibly just as well be done a minute or a second later; and this accursed possibility persists as long as one draws breath. No one can prove to me that a postponement lasting a second or a third¹ should have ruinous consequences, and because no one can prove it to me, my life comes to a complete standstill. My infinite brooding over it means that I accomplish nothing. Furthermore I come to think about my thoughts on the matter — indeed, I think about the fact that I think about it, and divide myself into an infinitely regressing series of selves that observe one another. I do not know which self is to be regarded as the genuine one, and the moment I stop at one, it is again a self that stops at it. I grow dizzy and overcome with vertigo, as though I were staring down into a bottomless abyss, and the thinking ends with my feeling a dreadful headache.

— Dear cousin, I said calmly, with such broodings you will torment yourself as fruitlessly as if you turned your Goliath frame inside out and tried to walk on your head with your long legs in the air. I cannot help you at all with sorting out your many selves. It lies entirely outside my sphere of competence, and I should have to be or become just as mad as you if I were to engage in your superhuman reveries. My way is to keep to tangible things and walk along the broad highway of common sense; that is why my selves never get into a muddle. Besides, I see well enough that

¹In the old sexagesimal division of time, a *secund* is what we now call a second (one sixtieth of a minute), and a *terts* is one sixtieth of a second.

the fault is mine. I ought to have led you straight to your destination, opened the Councillor's wife's door, and pushed you into the room in such a fashion that you would have found yourself obliged to seize upon whatever self came first to hand, in order to bid the lady and her good family good day. But tell me now, what have you been doing here for a full year?

— I have, he said, been collecting materials for my great work on the physical and intellectual nature of man.

— Oh, I replied, are you still thinking of that? Ten years ago you had the same fixed idea. It must be becoming a thoroughly substantial piece of work. I thought you were studying mineralogy, since I saw the great quantity of stones here on your floor.

— They are here solely for the sake of the work, he said. I have observed that thoughts flow best from the pen when one possesses entirely suitable writing implements. To have good pens, one must have good knives, and to sharpen them, one must possess really choice whetstones. Therefore, before proceeding further, I ordered various kinds of stone, and have indeed, as you see, had to penetrate rather deeply into mineralogy as a preparatory study.

— To which I replied: This seems a thoroughly rigorous method, provided you add to it a diligent study of ornithology in order to solve the problem of which birds' feathers yield the best quill-cases, and also sacrifice a few years to pedagogy in order to discover how a boy is best educated so as to become in time a capable and upright knife-grinder.

— Strictly speaking, that is not taking it too far, he said. You mock because you do not understand me. These experiments in facilitating intellectual activity through the convenience of material means also furnish contributions to the work itself, just as the observation of how I came to undertake the investigation constitutes a new chapter. Furthermore —

— Now stop there, cousin, I interrupted him, otherwise our thoughts will run into a tangle again, as when we lost our way among our selves. One should not row so far out that one loses sight of land.

In order to extricate myself and my cousin from the tangled cobweb of argument into which he is apt to draw us until I with my Jutland understanding am at last at a complete loss, I set about examining the state of his clothes; for in every practical matter he is utterly helpless. I found that his wardrobe, with the assistance of the

benevolent Marie, had been put in better order than I had expected. While I was occupied with this, I noticed that by keeping his coat buttoned he was giving his person a broader cross-section, so as to block my view of a certain corner. Whenever I tried to cast my eye in that direction he would trip around in front of my line of sight like a goose which with outspread wings seeks to defend its newly hatched brood against the dairymaid's hands; but she kicks the short-sighted goose aside with her wooden shoes and counts all the goslings in her flock in order to bring them in for the night. In like manner I, having detected the mischief, seized the desperate Licentiatius by the arm and said: Stand aside, cousin, I must see what contraband you have hidden here in the corner. Here I discovered a pile of mouldy collars and neckcloths which he had very carefully managed to conceal from Marie's watchful eye. With a ruler I stirred up the ill-kept linen and in so doing disturbed an entire tribe of earwigs in their domestic felicity. The fleeing swarm of insects escaped for the most part from my murderous pursuit by means of their numerous legs and supple bodies; but I cried out in indignation:

— Dearest cousin! Why in all the world do you conceal your failings from me? That you hide your slovenliness from the pretty miller's daughter I can understand; but that you should feel embarrassed before your own first cousin, who has so many times seen you in your full nakedness — that goes altogether too far.

— Bertel, he replied, I scarcely understand it myself. It is a curious psychological problem. It is with me as with a fatally ill person who does not even have the courage to reveal all his dangerous symptoms to the doctor. In this way a man on many occasions divides himself into two persons, of whom the one seeks to lead the other astray, while a third, who is at bottom the same as the other two, marvels greatly at this confusion. In short, thought becomes dramatic and plays in silence the most intricate intrigues with itself and for itself; but the spectator always becomes actor anew. I shall devote a long chapter to this in my work.